



What the 2026 price reversal can teach the 2027 restructure

143 weeks of US search data, 7,978 YouTube comments and a second case: Unity, 2023.



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Console image: Microsoft

01 Context • Executive summary

Customers punished the increase; the cut did not win them back



29.3×

Cancel searches the day after the increase, against 2.9× after the price cut



10 days

Until the backlash faded. The price cut came on day 202



~30M

Members by July 2026, down 4 to 5M. Sentiment recovered after the cut; members did not



2.7×

Godot's search interest two years after Unity's fee, against the year before it. Speed did not undo the switch

Thesis The increase likely paid, but cost trust. The 2027 risk is pairing a loss with a price cut, as in April 2026.

01 Context • The ask

Four decisions for the 2027 change, before November 2026

DECISION

EVIDENCE

WHAT IS AT STAKE

01	DECIDE		
	Announce the loss on its own No price change attached	2% → 17%	Call of Duty's share of comments when the April cut shipped with a loss
02	DECIDE		
	Give members three months' notice Announce in December, change in March	1.1×	Weekly cancel searches when July 2024 gave two months' notice. Oct 2025: 8.4×
03	APPROVE		
	Run four tests before setting a price Playtime, price survey, geo test, message A/B	16%	Share of comments public data can place in a segment
04	COMMIT		
	Judge the launch on 90-day retention Not on sentiment	~30M	Members held flat after the cut, while sentiment rose 11 pts



~30M

members to hold through the 2027 change

The reported 2027 plan repeats April's structure

	APRIL 2026 • CONFIRMED	2027 • REPORTED
The concession	Ultimate cut to \$22.99	Price cut of about \$3
The loss	Day-one Call of Duty removed	All day-one releases removed
How it shipped	Together, same day	Together, as reported

WHAT APRIL TAUGHT

17.1%

of comments were about Call of Duty after the cut

2.1%

17.1%

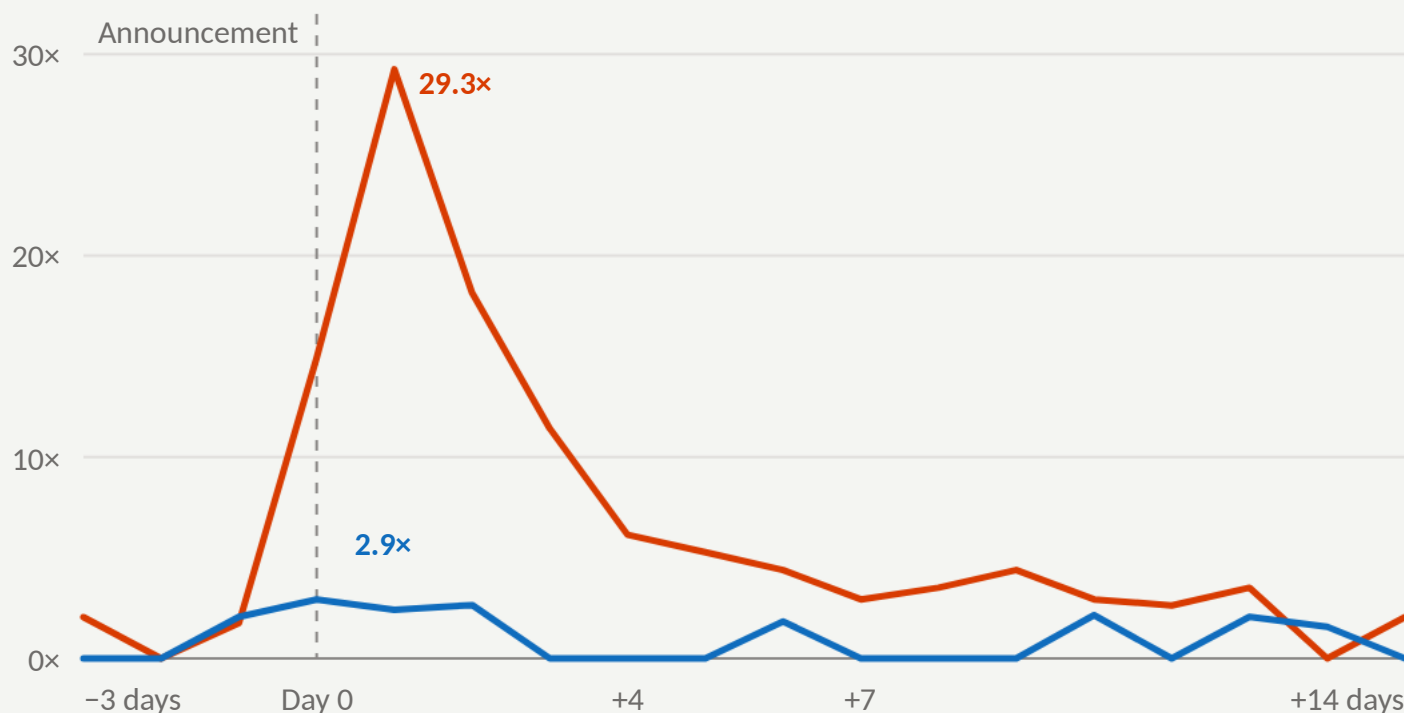
Up from 2.1% after the increase. The loss crowded out the price cut.

Same structure, bigger loss: in 2027 the removal covers every day-one release, not one franchise.

02 Evidence • Customer insight

The increase drew ten times the response of the cut

Price increase, Oct 2025 Price cut, Apr 2026



29.3x

Peak, day after the increase

2.9x

Peak, around the cut

10 days

Until the reaction faded. The cut came on day 202

02 Evidence • Customer insight

Sentiment recovered after the cut. Members did not

IN THE COMMENTS: RECOVERED

● Oct 2025 increase ● Apr 2026 cut

Cancellation talk

Down 81%

2.5% 13.0%

Rival mentions

Down 57%

5.1% 12.0%

Net sentiment

Up 11 pts

+13.8 +24.9

Share of 7,978 YouTube comments, and net score. Cancellation searches were back to normal within 10 days.

IN THE MEMBERSHIP: NOT RECOVERED

~30M

members by July 2026

~30M

34-35M

Reported peak to July 2026. No recovery after the April 2026 cut.

REVENUE CHECK • SPECULATION

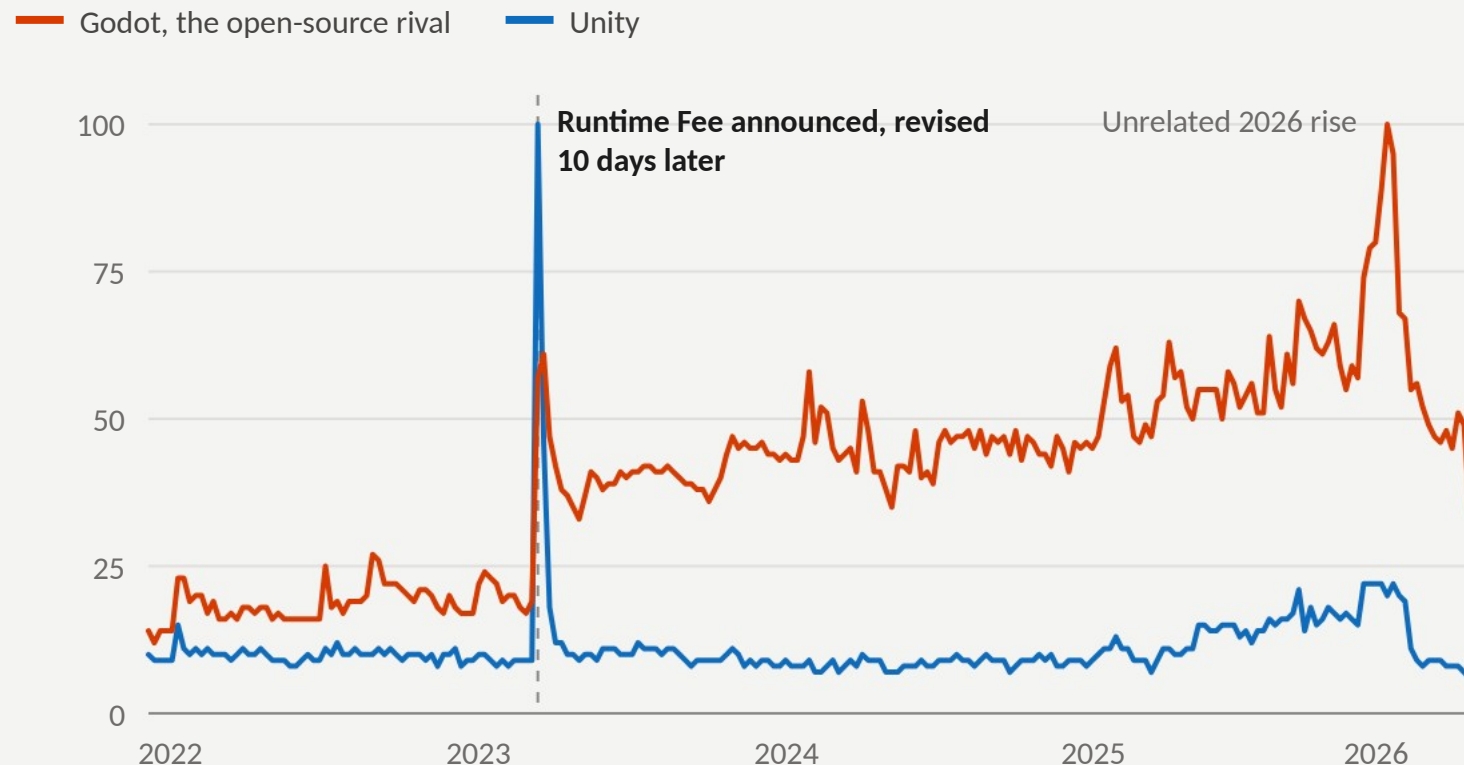
At +50%, Ultimate could lose a third of members before revenue fell. Members fell about 13%. The increase likely paid; the cost was trust.

The unhappy members had already left, so they stopped being counted. The recovery was survivorship, not satisfaction.

Sources: 7,978 YouTube comments; Google Trends, US. Membership press-reported. Console sales also fell, a second cause

02 Evidence • Validation

Unity reversed in ten days. Its rival's gains held



2.7×

Godot interest in Sep 2025, against the year before the fee

3 wks

For Unity's own interest to return to baseline

The pattern in both cases

Price shock, then customers try an alternative, find it good enough, and a reversal arrives after the switch.

2027 hits new-release players hardest



The Backlog Player

271 comments

2027 impact: Low

Pays for: Games they would buy anyway, for less

Our move: Message: costs less than buying the games

"I'll just pay \$0 a month to play my backlog"



The Loyalist Who Left

114 comments

2027 impact: Depends

Pays for: A long relationship with the platform

Our move: Three months' notice, nothing bundled

"For 20+ years I been subscribed to Xbox!"



The New-Release Player

923 comments

2027 impact: High

Pays for: Day-one access to new games

Our move: Size them first, then a retention plan

"What did it cost?" "COD." "Ahh, so nothing!"

One message: still cheaper than buying, and no surprises

Core message

Game Pass still costs less than buying the games you would play, and you will always know what is coming.

Pillar 1

Value

“Less than buying the games you would play”

- A year of Premium (\$180) costs less than five games (\$200)
- Price or value in 35% of comments



Leads for
The Backlog Player

Pillar 2

Predictability

“No surprises”

- Three months’ notice, and pricing announced separately
- July 2024 gave two months’ notice: 1.1× cancel searches, not 8.4×



Leads for
The Loyalist Who Left

Pillar 3

Fresh catalogue

“New games keep arriving, on a published schedule”

- Release schedule published on day 0 (to build)
- Catalogue share of playtime (test 1, to build)



Leads for
The New-Release Player

05 Launch plan

Announce in December, change in March, price in June

Dec 2026 • FY27 Q2

Announce the loss, with notice

Day-one releases move to a published schedule. Creators briefed a week early. No price change attached.

Judged on

Cancellation rate, first 10 days

Target: Below the Oct 2025 increase

Mar 2027 • FY27 Q3

The change lands

New releases arrive on schedule. A downgrade option shows before the cancel screen.

Judged on

Downgrades versus exits

Target: 1 in 3 leavers downgrade

Jun 2027 • FY27 Q4

Price the new tiers

Set from the price survey and geo test, and announced on its own.

Judged on

90-day retention at the new price

Target: At or above the 2025 cohort

Success 90-day retention of the members active on announcement day, not sentiment.